international, I would spend a day in the fields not knowing how England were progressing. I was simply experiencing a different life.

I don't do that much tractor work due to the obvious summer months constraints, but I do enjoy the odd day driving carting grain if I get the chance. After cricket I'm sure I will spend a lot more time on the tractor, certainly volunteering for the work when *TMS* is on. I look after the sheep more because I'm usually available when they need looking after most, just before the domestic cricket season begins.

I understand what some folk mean when they talk about the timelessness of the land, and its link to our forebears. Rural communities are closer to that old cycle of birth, marriage and death in a small geographical area. They're more deeply rooted. I appreciate country traditions, and I've fully bought into the romanticism of the landscape and lifestyle. It can be really hard work, but there's something almost poetic in spending the day with the dogs, erecting electric fences in the pouring rain.

What it can give, however, is balance and solitude. I enjoy my own company, having that day on my own, working through a list of jobs. I don't have to think too deeply and would certainly never have the cheek to believe I had the experience to make critical decisions on the farm. There's a difference between knowing how to look after a thousand sheep on your own and running a business.

Ultimately, that's what a farm is, a business. I appreciate the reality will upset some people, and hope they will take my honesty into consideration, but, as a meat eater, I am quite comfortable with the contradiction of doing everything possible to keep an animal alive for five months in the knowledge that it will eventually end up as someone's dinner.

Farmers are not uncaring people at all. In fact, most are the total opposite, going above and beyond to care for their livestock. I relish their company, appreciate their outlook and feel privileged to have been introduced to their world. I understand the timeless logic of waiting for lambs to grow, before they are sold. We breed commercial rather than pedigree sheep, so most of our lambs will be sold for meat.

I would love to run my own farm. It will be difficult as cricket demands a similar time commitment, but it's not an impossible balance to strike. The week leading up to one of my milestone achievements, the 294 against India at Edgbaston in 2011, involved several successive sixteen-hour days,